

BACK STAGE

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SHERIDAN-ELSON-PRODUCED FILM REAPS "SOLID GOLD"

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Hey, a sales film is a sales film right? An executive on camera behind a desk, a few graphs and a lot of product shots. See one you've seen them all. Until you see the one just completed for the Knickerbocker Toy Company.

Of course, going in, we had an unusual charge. Here we are, faced with an established toy company newly acquired by Warner Communications. They boast a magnificent array of new toys. Their management team is new and aggressive. But for all its newness we had a frustrating charge: Under no circumstances were we to use the word "new". There was another charge....

"Funny, it's got to be funny!" Stan Harfenist, VP-Sales and Marketing for Knickerbocker, told me. "Poke fun at us, poke fun at the toy trade, just make it funny." So, I laid off Russian novels and Swedish movies for awhile and came up with a concept revolving around two comedians hosting a disco TV show. That idea was just beginning to cook when another mandate was added. "Sell. There's got to be plenty of sell to the toy trade." Translation: Lots of technical copy about toy specifications, marketing data, ad budgets and like that.

Combining all that technical stuff into a hip, breezy, disco format wasn't the big problem. The problem was finding two comedians who could be funny while effectively delivering the drier elements of copy. To my mind, the list of hopefuls was short, beginning and ending with Tom and Dick Smothers.

Happily, Stan agreed wholeheartedly. Did I say wholehearted? He was emphatic. "We must have the Smothers Brothers!" If I could just convince the brothers of that.

In a week's time Tom and Dick had read the script and approved the project. Now the only hurdle that remained was time. Had I mentioned time? We were now in the third week of January. The production had to be in the can by February 5th. Hello, videotape.

Video wasn't just a logical choice. It was the only choice. Sure, time is forever creeping up the back of every production. But in this case it was creeping up the back, leaning over both shoulders and threatening to run past us before we began. Video was the answer to the obvious time considerations. But there was another pressure. Knickerbocker Toys is owned by Warner Communications, a name synonymous with production value.

Any short cuts we took could not show up in the final product. Video gave us both the time savings and creativity the project demanded.

Bob Elson, president of Sheridan-Elson Communications, took personal charge of line production. His was a particularly challenging task. The deadline and budget were both tight. Yet, as each element of production was added, it was becoming obvious that this was no ordinary show. His insistence on excellence helped make it extraordinary.

A cast of dancers had been recruited and rehearsed a few days before. Many of them came from the hit show, "The Best Little Whorehouse in Texas". They were placed under the direction of choreographer Sandy Quinn, whose influence immediately changed our thinking about how the dancers should be used. Originally, they were to have been used in background shots only, a means of establishing a proper disco mood. Sandy created a series of spectacular line disco routines that were so exciting we had to use them as the vehicle for the Smothers' finale.

Clearly, as each element was added to the production, we became aware that something spectacular was about to happen. The performances of Tom and Dick Smothers deepened that belief. They took a personal interest in all facets of production, set design, wardrobe, lighting, everything right down to cue card preparation. They demanded excellence. Of themselves and of those around them. They had a time stipulation in their contract, yet never looked at the clock. Their performances were a subtle blend of hilarity and persuasiveness. Their ad libs kept us up late during editing just deciding which ones to use.

But perhaps their contributions can best be explained in a single story. Our script called for an actor to play the part of a costumed superhero. Unfortunately, the actor chose to have a super temper tantrum and stalked off the set before we had finished taping his scene. We were left in an embarrassing position. It was too late to recast and the scene was too important to simply cut out. So, it was rewritten with Dick Smothers playing the superhero. He brought magic to the role and Tom's reactions helped make the bit the funniest in the show. But shooting ran late. They had a 7:30 PM curtain for their Broadway hit, "I Love My Wife". It was close to 7 PM before Dick, satisfied with the taped playbacks (thanks again, videotape), dashed to his waiting limo, resplendent in bright blue costume and flowing red cape. Sure hope he had time to change before walking on stage.

That last minute escape captures the essences of the entire production of "Knickerbocker, Solid Gold!" A frantic race against clock and logistics by a group of professionals who refused to let such hurdles prevent their creating a superior show. To those mentioned above, to these that follow and to the dozens I'm bound to miss, special thanks for your contributions.

Thanks to Unitel, especially the red-eye detail for an overnight miracle. To Reeves Teletape and post production supervisor Jerry Newman, for allowing our imaginations to run wild with the many electronic toys you have there. To Winkler Video for the constant watchcare of Wendy Friend. To Image Transform for a great tape-to-film transfer. To Dick Hillegas and Nora Glass of Knickerbocker for handling the mind-boggling logistics of getting the product before the cameras. To Stan Harfenist for vision and for not blowing his lines. To Peter Heinz and the entire organization at Rosenfeld, Sirowitz and Lawson. Without your many green lights, there'd never be any solid gold.



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